

the laws, creating a minefield for taxpayers. Then they are paid high fees to help the wealthy get through it.

Yes, hard structures can be very complicated. You will often find yourself gazing far into the distance when someone is talking about them. You will hope your advisers and other family members are paying attention; you won't want to.

Often, these setups are so dense in technicalities and legal esoterica that you have no idea what is involved. Sometimes the complexity is just legal mumbo jumbo. Sometimes it is important. And you'll have to work hard to figure out which is which.

Many people find setting up these hard structures so costly and annoying that they don't bother with them at all. "Let the next generation sort it out," they say to themselves. Often, they dislike the implications of the hard structure systems, too—and the need to guess about things that won't happen for years—or they need to think about things they hope will never happen.

"Let's see, if you are killed in a car crash tomorrow, God forbid," the estate tax attorney begins, "what do you want to happen to your wealth?"

A lot of people don't want to hear the question, let alone answer it. Many others do not appreciate the suggestions that follow. In order to avoid a disaster after they are gone, they will be advised to give up control or ownership of assets during their lifetimes.

Successful estate planning/tax avoidance comes at a price. First, you have to be able to do the work. Paying someone else to do it isn't enough. You have to make sure it is done the way you want. And then you have to understand it well enough so you can stick to the plan. Finally, you have to follow through, often doing things that make you nervous, over a period of many years.

There are four key "hard structures" you need:

- A will and an estate plan
- A trust
- A tax strategy
- Investment/bank accounts

They are all connected. And all can take many, many different forms designed to fit an infinite variety of situations. And since people are